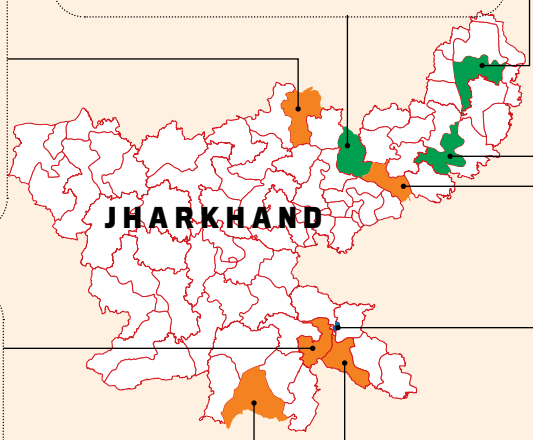
PRESTIGE BATTLES

Family ties, shifting loyalties, past rivalries in key constituencies



BARHAIT



HEMANT SOREN, JMM
Chief Minister

Main opponent
GAMLIYEL HEMBROM, BJP
In 2019, Gamliyel had secured only 2,573 votes in Barhait as an AJSU candidate

DUMKA



BASANT SOREN, JMM
Hemant Soren's younger brother

Main opponent
SUNIL SOREN, BJP
Basant is faced with a strong challenge as Sunil is a former MP who defeated Shibu Soren in the Dumka LS seat in 2019

DHANWAR



BABULAL MARANDI, BJP
State BJP president

Main opponents
Raj Kumar Yadav, CPI-ML
Nizamuddin Ansari, JMM
In 2014, Yadav defeated Marandi, though the latter reclaimed the seat in 2019 as a JVM candidate

GANDEY



KALPANA SOREN, JMM
Wife of Hemant Soren

Main opponent
MUNIYA DEVI, BJP
Kalpana won the seat in a by-election in May while her husband was in judicial custody. Muniya is a leader from the Kushwaha community

JAMTARA



SITA SOREN, BJP, *Hemant Soren's estranged sister-in-law*

Main opponent
IRFAN ANSARI Congress
Sita joined the BJP after winning Jama as a JMM candidate in 2019. Ansari won the Jamtara seat in 2014 and 2019

JAMSHEDPUR EAST



PURNIMA DAS SAHU, BJP
Daughter-in-law of Odisha governor Raghubar Das

Main opponent
AJOY KUMAR Congress
Purnima is contesting the seat previously held by Raghubar Das, who lost it in 2019 despite serving as CM

SARAIKELA



CHAMPAI SOREN BJP, *former CM*

Main opponent
GANESH MAHLI, JMM
Soren won the seat on a JMM ticket in 2019. Mahli has switched to the JMM from BJP after losing both the 2014 and 2019 polls

JAGANNATHPUR



GEETA KODA, BJP
Wife of former CM Madhu Koda

Main opponent
SONA RAM SINKU Congress
Geeta won in 2009 and 2014, Sinku in 2019 when Geeta won the Chaibasa LS seat on a Cong. ticket. She joined the BJP to fight the LS polls but lost

POTKA



MEERA MUNDA, BJP
Wife of Arjun Munda

Main opponent
SANJIB SARDAR JMM
Meera has the support of former BJP MLA Menka Sardar, who initially threatened to rebel but is now backing her against sitting MLA Sanjib

MAKE OR BREAK

With members of several political families in the fray, this election promises to be as much a referendum on legacy as on leadership. Take the Soren family, for instance. Kalpana, Hemant and his younger brother Basant are running under the JMM banner, while Sita Soren, Hemant's estranged sister-in-law who switched to the BJP to unsuccessfully contest the Lok Sabha polls, is soliciting votes in the name of her husband Durga Soren, Hemant's deceased brother.

For some, like Arjun Munda, the stakes are far higher than mere victory for his wife Meera. Having tasted defeat in the Lok Sabha polls, Munda has now pinned his aspirations on her. If she wins, it could revive his diminishing political stock, and position him as a potential CM candidate. There are others in this cohort of proxy candidates: former CM Madhu Koda's wife, Geeta (Jagannathpur) and former CM Raghubar Das's daughter-in-law, Purnima Das Sahu (Jamshedpur East).

Then there are the likes of Champai Soren and his son Babulal, contesting in neighbouring Saraikela and Ghatshila, respectively, whose political careers are on the line. Word is that some senior BJP leaders were initially hesitant about including the father-son duo,